A little book of tiny guests

Tiny Guests

Name _____ Date _____



Little Wonderer held a magnifier beside the sink. “Can I see the tiny guests on my hands?” “Germs are far too small for just our eyes,” said Big. “Even that magnifier cannot show them.” They opened a book. Bacteria and viruses waited on its pages. Were these tiny guests alike?



Little paused at a yogurt cup. “Are all bacteria a problem?” “Many are helpers,” said Big. “Some live happily in your gut and help with food. Others help make yogurt. Some can make people unwell.” A bacterium is one whole living cell: a tiny unit with the parts it needs to live.



The next guest was much smaller. A virus is a tiny package of instructions in a coat, not a cell. It cannot make copies alone. It must borrow a living cell’s machinery: the parts that do the work. “Like a program saying ‘copy me’?” asked Little. “Instructions that need a cell,” said Big.

bacteria	tiny living things, each made of one whole cell
cell	a tiny unit that living things are made of
virus	a package of instructions in a coat that needs a cell to make copies
soap	a cleaner that loosens germs and can pull apart oily layers
antibiotic	a medicine that works on bacteria, not viruses
immune system	your body’s defenders, including cells that can learn and remember

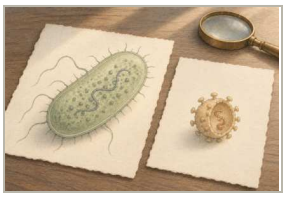
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Back at the sink, Little made a soft lather. Soap can pull apart the oily outer layers of many germs. It also loosens germs from skin. “Wet. Add soap. Scrub for 20 seconds. Rinse. Dry,” Little said. Water carried the loosened guests away. A small habit could do a lot.



“Does one medicine work on both guests?” Little asked. Big shook their head. “An antibiotic is a medicine that works on bacteria. It does not work on viruses, because they do not have the same cell parts.” Little compared the two shapes again. Different tiny guests needed different kinds of help.



“Your immune system is your body’s team of defenders,” said Big. “Some learn to recognize germs and remember them next time.” Little saved a shape in the notebook, then a command: “Rinse your hands well.” What other kind habits could Little keep?

1. How is a bacterium different from a virus?
2. How do soap, scrubbing, and rinsing work together?
3. What can some of your body’s defenders remember, and why does it help?

Your turn

Write one command sentence for washing hands.

Example: First wet your hands, then scrub with soap for 20 seconds.